

Generalized Pandrosion Residuals

Residual profile of an iterative geometric construction for p -th roots of any positive real number

Ivan BESEVIC

April 2026

Abstract

We revisit Pandrosion's classical geometric construction, reported by Pappus, for approximating the cube root of two and generalize it to the computation of p^{th} roots of any positive real x by inserting proportional means using Thales' theorem. In our formulation the construction reduces to a single parameter $s_n \in (0, 1)$ together with an output v_n converging to $x^{1/p}$. After a normalization the iteration takes a universal form involving the geometric sum

$$S_p(s) = 1 + s + \cdots + s^{p-1}.$$

We identify the unique fixed point $s^* = x^{-1/p}$, show that the convergence is *linear*, and derive an explicit closed-form expression for the associated contraction ratio

$$\lambda_{p,x} = \frac{(\alpha - 1) \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{p-1-k}}{\sum_{k=0}^{p-1} \alpha^k}, \quad \alpha = x^{1/p}.$$

This ratio depends only on the target α ; throughout the paper we refer to it as the *convergence signature* of Pandrosion's method, a memorable shorthand for what is formally the standard asymptotic error constant $h'(s^*)$ of a linearly convergent fixed-point iteration. Building on this formula we obtain non-asymptotic error bounds, prove that $\lambda_{p,x}$ is monotonic in both the order p and the argument x , extend the construction to the case $0 < x < 1$ (where convergence becomes oscillatory), and determine an optimal starting point that minimizes the initial error. We further show that Steffensen's acceleration applied to the Pandrosion iteration yields *quadratic* convergence, and we propose a simple scaling strategy that exploits the monotonicity of $\lambda_{p,x}$ to reduce the computational cost for large x . Taken together, these results situate an ancient geometric procedure within modern fixed-point theory and suggest derivative-free root-finding algorithms inspired by Pandrosion.

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1 Introduction

The Greek problem of doubling the cube consists of constructing a segment of length $\sqrt[3]{2}$ from a unit segment. It is equivalent to finding two proportional means m_1, m_2 between 1 and 2, that

is,

$$\frac{1}{m_1} = \frac{m_1}{m_2} = \frac{m_2}{2},$$

which yields $m_1 = \sqrt[3]{2}$ and $m_2 = \sqrt[3]{4}$. Pandrosion of Alexandria proposed an *approximate* geometric method, reported by Pappus in the *Collectio*, Book III [3]: by successive parallels (Thales' theorem), she constructs proportional ratios that approach these means without ever reaching them exactly in a finite number of steps.

This work starts from a fundamental observation:

Mathematically the target number is exact, but any approximation procedure yields a measurable residual profile — a footprint intrinsic to the chosen method.

At each finite step of Pandrosion's construction, there remains a gap $\varepsilon_n = |v_n - \alpha|$ between the geometric approximation and the ideal value. The sequence (ε_n) is the **residual profile** of the method. Our goal is to compute this profile exactly for any p -th root $x^{1/p}$, and to identify the contraction ratio that characterizes Pandrosion's method.

Positioning and related work. Rational iterations for p -th roots are a classical topic with a large literature: Newton's method applied to $f(u) = u^p - x$, Halley's method, and more generally Schröder's (1870) and König's (1884) families produce iterations of arbitrary order with explicit asymptotic constants. The systematic analysis of fixed-point iterations and their acceleration goes back to Ostrowski [9], Traub [11], and Householder [10]; the derivative-free counterpart via Aitken–Steffensen (1926/1933) is standard and appears in every modern numerical-analysis textbook [5, 6]. What is specific to the iteration (3) below is that it arises directly from Pandrosion's geometric construction, *without* being derived as Newton or Schröder applied to a particular polynomial: it is a rational iteration with linear (not quadratic) order, whose contraction ratio admits the closed form (5) as a rational function of $\alpha = x^{1/p}$. We have not located this closed form, together with its monotonicity in (p, x) and its use to drive a scaling preconditioning, in the textbooks [5, 6] or the historical literature on cube duplication, but we make no claim that the iteration itself is genuinely new: the contribution is to record the profile of a specific historical iteration and to show how standard acceleration devices (Aitken Δ^2 , scaling) interact with it.

Outline. Section 2 recalls Pandrosion's construction for $\sqrt[3]{2}$ and analyzes its residual profile. Section 4 states the generalization to any p, x . Section 5 computes the contraction ratio $\lambda_{p,x}$ and provides closed-form expressions. Section 7 presents numerical tables. Section 8 compares with bisection, the secant method, and Newton's method. Section 9 establishes functional properties of $\lambda_{p,x}$. Section 10 provides non-asymptotic error bounds. Section 11 extends the theory to $x < 1$. Section 12 determines the optimal starting point. Section 13 shows that Steffensen's acceleration of Pandrosion achieves quadratic convergence. Section 14 exploits the monotonicity of $\lambda_{p,x}$ to optimize the method for large x via scaling. Section 15 concludes.

2 Pandrosion's construction for $\sqrt[3]{2}$

2.1 The two sequences

The geometric construction produces two sequences as a function of an initial parameter u_0 :

$$u_{n+1} = \frac{u_n}{2 - 2\left(\frac{4 - u_n}{4}\right)^3}, \quad v_n = 2\left(\frac{4 - u_n}{4}\right)^2, \quad u_0 = 0.5. \quad (1)$$

The sequence (u_n) is the *internal parameter* of the construction (a length in the Thales diagram). The sequence (v_n) is the *readout*: the approximation of $\sqrt[3]{2}$ produced at step n .

Proposition 2.1. $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} v_n = \sqrt[3]{2}$.

2.2 Normalized substitution

Setting $s_n = (4 - u_n)/4$, so that $s_n \in (0, 1)$, we obtain:

- $u_n = 4(1 - s_n)$,
- $v_n = 2s_n^2$,
- $u_{n+1} = \frac{4(1 - s_n)}{2(1 - s_n^3)} = \frac{2}{1 + s_n + s_n^2}$.

The iteration on s_n then becomes:

$$s_{n+1} = 1 - \frac{u_{n+1}}{4} = \frac{2s_n^2 + 2s_n + 1}{2s_n^2 + 2s_n + 2}. \quad (2)$$

2.3 Fixed point

The fixed point s^* satisfies $s^* = (2s^{*2} + 2s^* + 1)/(2s^{*2} + 2s^* + 2)$, which gives $2(1 - s^*)(1 + s^* + s^{*2}) = 1$, i.e. $2(1 - s^{*3}) = 1$, hence $s^{*3} = 1/2$, so:

$$s^* = 2^{-1/3} = \frac{1}{\sqrt[3]{2}}.$$

The output at the fixed point is $v^* = 2s^{*2} = 2 \cdot 2^{-2/3} = 2^{1/3} = \sqrt[3]{2}$. ✓

2.4 Residual profile: linear convergence

Let $h(s) = (2s^2 + 2s + 1)/(2s^2 + 2s + 2)$. The derivative at s^* gives the convergence rate:

$$h'(s^*) = \frac{4s^* + 2}{(2s^{*2} + 2s^* + 2)^2} = \frac{2(2s^* + 1)}{4(s^{*2} + s^* + 1)^2} = \frac{2s^* + 1}{2(s^{*2} + s^* + 1)^2}.$$

Substituting $s^* = 2^{-1/3}$ and using the closed form (7):

$$\lambda_{3,2} = \frac{(\sqrt[3]{2} - 1)(\sqrt[3]{2} + 2)}{\sqrt[3]{4} + \sqrt[3]{2} + 1} \approx 0.2202.$$

Theorem 2.1 (Linear residual law for $p = 3$, $x = 2$). Under the above hypotheses, for any s_0 sufficiently close to s^* :

$$\varepsilon_{n+1}^{(s)} \approx \lambda_{3,2} \varepsilon_n^{(s)}, \quad \lambda_{3,2} \approx 0.2202.$$

Since $v_n - \sqrt[3]{2} \approx (p - 1)\alpha^2 (s_n - s^*)$ and $(p - 1)\alpha^2 = 2 \cdot \sqrt[3]{4}$, the output residual of v_n converges at the same linear rate.

3 Geometric origin: why S_p arises naturally

3.1 The construction by successive parallels

Pandrosion's construction relies on Thales' theorem applied to a rectangle. Consider a rectangle with sides H and W equipped with two diagonals (Figure 1). A horizontal line at height u_n from the bottom intersects the two diagonals and defines:

- the parameter $s_n = (H - u_n)/H$ (normalized position from the top),

n	s_n	v_n	$\varepsilon_n = v_n - \sqrt[3]{2} $	$\varepsilon_{n+1}/\varepsilon_n$
0	0.8750	1.5312	2.713×10^{-1}	—
1	0.8107	1.3143	5.44×10^{-2}	0.200
2	0.7974	1.2717	1.17×10^{-2}	0.216
3	0.7945	1.2625	2.58×10^{-3}	0.219
4	0.7939	1.2605	5.67×10^{-4}	0.220
∞	$2^{-1/3}$	$\sqrt[3]{2}$	0	$\rightarrow \lambda_{3,2}$

Table 1: Numerical residual profile for $p = 3$, $x = 2$ ($u_0 = 0.5$, i.e. $s_0 = 0.875$). The ratio converges to $\lambda_{3,2} \approx 0.220$.

- the readout length $v_n = x \cdot s_n^{p-1}$ (the output of the construction).

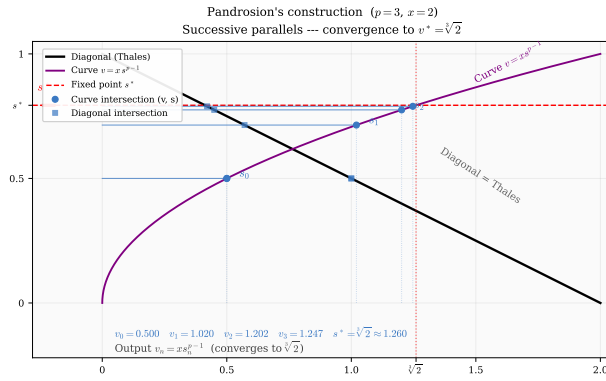


Figure 1: Pandrosion's geometric construction for $p = 3$, $x = 2$. The blue horizontal lines (steps $n = 0, 1, 2, 3$) converge toward the dashed red line, which corresponds to $v^* = \sqrt[3]{2}$.

3.2 Where does the polynomial S_p come from?

The fundamental idea is as follows. We seek to insert $p - 1$ proportional means between 1 and x , that is, to construct the ideal geometric sequence $1, \alpha, \alpha^2, \dots, \alpha^{p-1}, x$ where $\alpha = x^{1/p}$. If $s_n \approx \alpha^{-1}$ is the current approximation of the inverse ratio, the sum of the approximate geometric sequence is:

$$S_p(s_n) = 1 + s_n + s_n^2 + \dots + s_n^{p-1}.$$

The ideal sequence satisfies $x \cdot S_p(s^*) \cdot (1 - s^*) = x - 1$, which rewrites as $x(1 - s^{*p}) = x - 1$. Pandrosion's correction adjusts s_n so as to reduce the gap between $S_p(s_n)$ and its ideal value via the formula:

$$s_{n+1} = 1 - \frac{x - 1}{x \cdot S_p(s_n)}.$$

Geometrically, the ratio $(x - 1)/(x \cdot S_p(s_n))$ measures the *deviation* of the current proportional chain from the perfect geometric chain, and subtraction from 1 produces the corrected ratio. The polynomial S_p is thus the analytical transcription of the sum of the p segments constructed via Thales' theorem.

4 Generalization: Pandrosion's construction for $x^{1/p}$

4.1 The universal iteration

Let $x > 0$ and $p \geq 2$ be an integer. Set $\alpha = x^{1/p}$. The generalized Pandrosion geometric construction is defined as follows.

Definition 4.1 (Generalized Pandrosion iteration). We define the sequence $(s_n)_{n \geq 0}$ in $(0, 1)$ by

$$s_{n+1} = 1 - \frac{x-1}{x \cdot S_p(s_n)}, \quad S_p(s) = \sum_{k=0}^{p-1} s^k = \frac{1-s^p}{1-s}, \quad (3)$$

and the output sequence by

$$v_n = x \cdot s_n^{p-1}. \quad (4)$$

We call $\varepsilon_n = |v_n - \alpha|$ the **Pandrosion residual** at step n .

Remark 4.1. For $p = 3$, $x = 2$, we recover exactly the iteration (2). Indeed:

$$1 - \frac{1}{2(1+s+s^2)} = \frac{2s^2+2s+1}{2s^2+2s+2} \cdot \checkmark$$

4.2 Geometric interpretation

The iteration (3) analytically translates the Thales operation: at each step, $S_p(s_n)$ measures the “geometric sum” of the constructed segments, and the correction $(x-1)/(x \cdot S_p(s_n))$ adjusts the position proportionally to the gap with the ideal geometric sequence $1, \alpha, \alpha^2, \dots, \alpha^{p-1}, x$.

4.3 Fixed point

Theorem 4.1 (Fixed point). The unique fixed point of the iteration (3) in $(0, 1)$ is $s^* = x^{-1/p} = \alpha^{-1}$. The corresponding output is $v^* = x \cdot (x^{-1/p})^{p-1} = x^{1/p} = \alpha$.

Proof. At a fixed point s^* , we have $1 - (x-1)/(x \cdot S_p(s^*)) = s^*$, i.e.

$$x \cdot S_p(s^*) \cdot (1 - s^*) = x - 1.$$

Since $S_p(s)(1-s) = 1-s^p$, this gives $x(1-s^{*p}) = x-1$, hence $s^{*p} = 1/x$, i.e. $s^* = x^{-1/p}$. The formula for v^* follows immediately. $\square$

5 The contraction ratio $\lambda_{p,x}$

5.1 General computation

Theorem 5.1 (Pandrosion contraction ratio). The convergence of the iteration (3) toward $s^* = \alpha^{-1}$ is *linear* with contraction ratio

$$\lambda_{p,x} = \frac{(\alpha-1) \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{p-1-k}}{\sum_{k=0}^{p-1} \alpha^k}, \quad \alpha = x^{1/p}. \quad (5)$$

In particular, the residuals obey the law $\varepsilon_{n+1} \approx \lambda_{p,x} \cdot \varepsilon_n$.

Proof. Let $h(s) = 1 - (x - 1)/(x \cdot S_p(s))$. Then

$$h'(s) = \frac{x-1}{x} \cdot \frac{S'_p(s)}{S_p(s)^2},$$

where $S'_p(s) = \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k s^{k-1}$.

At the fixed point $s^* = \alpha^{-1}$:

$$\begin{aligned} S_p(s^*) &= \frac{1 - \alpha^{-p}}{1 - \alpha^{-1}} = \frac{\alpha(x-1)}{x(\alpha-1)}, \\ S'_p(s^*) &= \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{-(k-1)} = \alpha \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{-k}. \end{aligned}$$

Substituting:

$$h'(s^*) = \frac{x-1}{x} \cdot \frac{\alpha \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{-k}}{\left[\frac{\alpha(x-1)}{x(\alpha-1)} \right]^2} = \frac{x(\alpha-1)^2}{\alpha(x-1)} \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{-k}.$$

Multiplying numerator and denominator by α^{p-1} , and using $x = \alpha^p$:

$$h'(s^*) = \frac{(\alpha-1)^2 \alpha^{p-1} \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{-k}}{\alpha^p - 1} = \frac{(\alpha-1) \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{p-1-k}}{\sum_{k=0}^{p-1} \alpha^k},$$

where we used $\alpha^p - 1 = (\alpha - 1) \sum_{k=0}^{p-1} \alpha^k$. This establishes (5). $\square$

Remark 5.1. The contraction ratio $\lambda_{p,x}$ is entirely determined by $\alpha = x^{1/p}$: the target itself dictates the rate at which Pandrosion's method approaches it. We will occasionally refer to $\lambda_{p,x}$, viewed as a rational function of α , as the *convergence signature* of the method. This is purely terminological — $\lambda_{p,x}$ is of course nothing more than $h'(s^*)$, the standard asymptotic error constant of a linearly convergent fixed-point iteration — and we introduce the name only to make the dependence on the target (rather than on the starting point) verbally prominent.

5.2 Closed forms for $p = 2$ and $p = 3$

For $p = 2$: $\sum_{k=1}^1 k \alpha^0 = 1$, $\sum_{k=0}^1 \alpha^k = 1 + \alpha$.

$$\lambda_{2,x} = \frac{\alpha-1}{\alpha+1} = \frac{\sqrt{x}-1}{\sqrt{x}+1}. \quad (6)$$

For $p = 3$: $\sum_{k=1}^2 k \alpha^{2-k} = \alpha + 2$, $\sum_{k=0}^2 \alpha^k = \alpha^2 + \alpha + 1$.

$$\lambda_{3,x} = \frac{(\alpha-1)(\alpha+2)}{\alpha^2 + \alpha + 1} = \frac{(\sqrt[3]{x}-1)(\sqrt[3]{x}+2)}{\sqrt[3]{x^2} + \sqrt[3]{x} + 1}. \quad (7)$$

For $p = 4$: $\sum_{k=1}^3 k \alpha^{3-k} = \alpha^2 + 2\alpha + 3$, $\sum_{k=0}^3 \alpha^k = \alpha^3 + \alpha^2 + \alpha + 1$.

$$\lambda_{4,x} = \frac{(\alpha-1)(\alpha^2 + 2\alpha + 3)}{\alpha^3 + \alpha^2 + \alpha + 1}. \quad (8)$$

Remark 5.2 (Asymptotic behavior in x). For any fixed $p \geq 2$ and $x \rightarrow \infty$, $\lambda_{p,x} \rightarrow 1^-$ (the dominant terms in numerator and denominator of (5) are both of order α^{p-1} with a ratio tending to 1). The larger x , the slower the convergence. For $x \rightarrow 1^+$, $\lambda_{p,x} \rightarrow 0$ by Proposition 9.1(1): convergence is very fast near 1.

5.3 Basin of attraction

Theorem 5.2 (Global convergence). For any $x > 1$ and any $p \geq 2$, the iteration (3) converges to s^* for all $s_0 \in (0, 1)$. Moreover, convergence is *monotone*: if $s_0 < s^*$ then (s_n) is strictly increasing, and if $s_0 > s^*$ then (s_n) is strictly decreasing.

Proof. Set $h(s) = 1 - (x - 1)/(x \cdot S_p(s))$.

Step 1: h is strictly increasing. We have $h'(s) = \frac{x-1}{x} \cdot \frac{S_p'(s)}{S_p(s)^2}$, where $S_p'(s) = \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k s^{k-1} > 0$ for $s > 0$.

Step 2: h maps $(0, 1)$ into itself. For $s \in (0, 1)$, $S_p(s) > 1$ since the first term equals 1 and the remaining terms are strictly positive. Hence $(x - 1)/(x S_p(s)) < (x - 1)/x < 1$, which gives $h(s) > 0$. On the other hand $(x - 1)/(x S_p(s)) > 0$ for $x > 1$, so $h(s) < 1$. Thus $h((0, 1)) \subset (0, 1)$. (At the boundary: $h(0^+) = 1 - (x - 1)/x = 1/x \in (0, 1)$ and $h(1^-) = 1 - (x - 1)/(xp) \in (0, 1)$.)

Step 3: monotone convergence. Since h is increasing and $h(s^*) = s^*$, if $s_0 < s^*$ then $s_1 = h(s_0) < h(s^*) = s^*$, and $s_1 = h(s_0) > h(0^+) = 1/x > 0$. By induction, (s_n) remains in $(0, s^*)$. Moreover, $h(s) > s$ for $s < s^*$ (since $h(s) - s$ changes sign only at s^* and $h'(s^*) < 1$), so (s_n) is strictly increasing and bounded, hence convergent, necessarily to s^* . The case $s_0 > s^*$ is symmetric. $\square$

5.4 Bound on the number of iterations

Proposition 5.1 (Cost of Pandrosion's method). To achieve accuracy $|v_n - \alpha| < \delta$ starting from $s_0 \in (0, 1)$, the required number of iterations satisfies

$$n_\delta \leq \left\lceil \frac{\ln(\varepsilon_0/\delta)}{\ln(1/\lambda_{p,x})} \right\rceil,$$

where $\varepsilon_0 = |v_0 - \alpha|$ is the initial error.

Proof. Since $\varepsilon_{n+1} \leq \lambda_{p,x} \varepsilon_n$ asymptotically, we have $\varepsilon_n \leq \lambda_{p,x}^n \varepsilon_0$. The inequality $\lambda_{p,x}^n \varepsilon_0 < \delta$ gives $n > \ln(\varepsilon_0/\delta)/\ln(1/\lambda_{p,x})$. $\square$

Example 5.1. For $p = 3$, $x = 2$ ($\lambda_{3,2} \approx 0.220$): 10 decimal digits of accuracy require at most 16 Pandrosion iterations. For $p = 3$, $x = 8$ ($\lambda_{3,8} = 4/7$): 43 iterations are needed.

6 Graphical illustrations

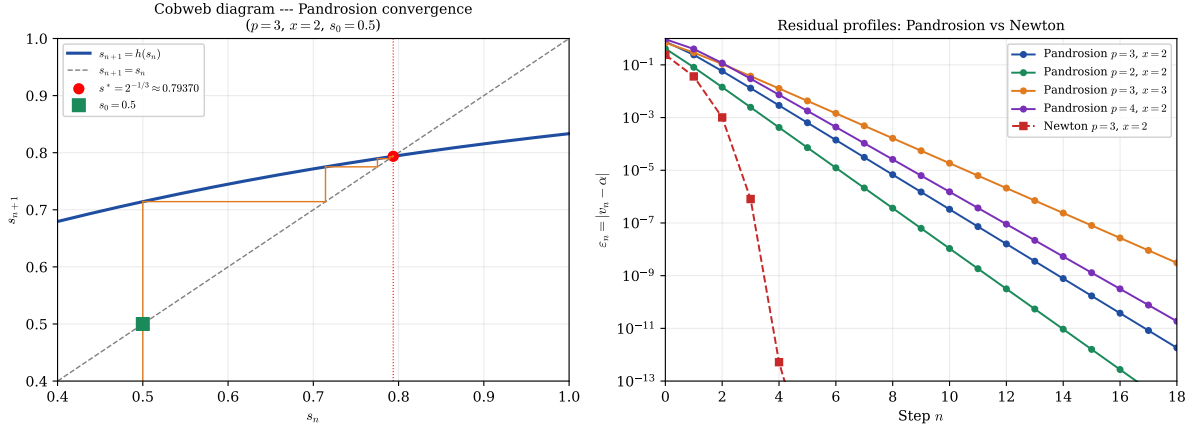


Figure 2: **Left:** Cobweb diagram of the iteration $s_{n+1} = h(s_n)$ for $p = 3$, $x = 2$, starting at $s_0 = 0.875$. The spiral converges to $s^* = 2^{-1/3}$ with rate $\lambda_{3,2} \approx 0.220$. **Right:** Residual profiles on a semi-logarithmic scale. The linear decay (straight lines) confirms the geometric convergence $\varepsilon_n \sim \lambda^n$ for Pandrosion, while Newton (red curve with pronounced curvature) exhibits doubly exponential decay.

7 Numerical examples

7.1 Table of contraction ratios

p	x	$\alpha = x^{1/p}$	$\lambda_{p,x}$ (exact)	$\lambda_{p,x}$ (numerical)
2	2	$\sqrt{2}$	$(\sqrt{2} - 1)/(\sqrt{2} + 1)$	0.1716
2	3	$\sqrt{3}$	$(\sqrt{3} - 1)/(\sqrt{3} + 1)$	0.2679
2	5	$\sqrt{5}$	$(\sqrt{5} - 1)/(\sqrt{5} + 1)$	0.3820
3	2	$\sqrt[3]{2}$	$(\sqrt[3]{2} - 1)(\sqrt[3]{2} + 2)/(\sqrt[3]{4} + \sqrt[3]{2} + 1)$	0.2202
3	3	$\sqrt[3]{3}$	$(\sqrt[3]{3} - 1)(\sqrt[3]{3} + 2)/(\sqrt[3]{9} + \sqrt[3]{3} + 1)$	0.3366
3	8	2	$(2 - 1)(2 + 2)/(4 + 2 + 1)$	0.5714
4	2	$\sqrt[4]{2}$	(formula (8))	0.2427
4	16	2	$(2 - 1)(4 + 4 + 3)/(8 + 4 + 2 + 1)$	0.7333
5	2	$\sqrt[5]{2}$	(general formula)	0.2565

Table 2: Contraction ratios $\lambda_{p,x}$ for various values of p and x . A value close to 0 means very fast convergence; close to 1, very slow.

7.2 Detailed numerical profile for $p = 2$, $x = 2$

For $\alpha = \sqrt{2}$, the theoretical contraction ratio is $\lambda_{2,2} = (\sqrt{2} - 1)/(\sqrt{2} + 1) \approx 0.1716$ (formula (6)). The iteration is:

$$s_{n+1} = 1 - \frac{1}{2(1 + s_n)}, \quad v_n = 2s_n.$$

n	s_n	v_n	$\varepsilon_n = v_n - \sqrt{2} $	$\varepsilon_{n+1}/\varepsilon_n$
0	0.7500	1.5000	8.579×10^{-2}	—
1	0.7143	1.4286	1.44×10^{-2}	0.167
2	0.7083	1.4167	2.45×10^{-3}	0.171
3	0.7073	1.4146	4.21×10^{-4}	0.171
4	0.7071	1.4143	7.22×10^{-5}	0.172
5	0.7071	1.4142	1.24×10^{-5}	0.171
∞	$1/\sqrt{2}$	$\sqrt{2}$	0	$\rightarrow \lambda_{2,2}$

Table 3: Numerical profile for $p = 2$, $x = 2$, $s_0 = 0.75$. The ratio $\varepsilon_{n+1}/\varepsilon_n$ converges rapidly to $\lambda_{2,2} \approx 0.172$.

7.3 The residual as a characterization of a target

Formula (5) implies a useful observation: *for every integer $n \geq 1$, we have $\lambda_{p,\alpha^p} = f(\alpha)$ where f is a rational function of α alone.* In particular, the residual profile depends only on the value of the sought root α and not on its representation as $x = \alpha^p$.

In particular, for $p = 3$:

$$\lambda_{3,x} = \frac{(\alpha - 1)(\alpha + 2)}{\alpha^2 + \alpha + 1} \xrightarrow{\alpha \rightarrow 1} 0, \quad \lambda_{3,x} \xrightarrow{\alpha \rightarrow \infty} 1.$$

8 Comparison with other methods

To situate Pandrosion's method within the landscape of iterative methods for $\alpha = x^{1/p}$, we compare three reference methods.

8.1 Newton's method

Newton's method for $f(u) = u^p - x$ gives the iteration

$$u_{n+1} = \frac{(p-1)u_n + x/u_n^{p-1}}{p},$$

whose convergence to $\alpha = x^{1/p}$ is *quadratic*:

$$\varepsilon_{n+1}^{\text{Newton}} \approx K_{p,x} (\varepsilon_n^{\text{Newton}})^2, \quad K_{p,x} = \frac{p-1}{2\alpha}.$$

8.2 Bisection

Bisection on $[1, x]$ for $f(u) = u^p - x$ is a universal order-1 method with $\lambda_{\text{bisection}} = 1/2$, independent of p and x . Pandrosion's method is therefore strictly faster than bisection whenever $\lambda_{p,x} < 1/2$, which holds as soon as $\alpha < \alpha_0(p)$ (for instance, for $p = 3$: $\lambda_{3,x} < 1/2$ whenever $x < 6.75$).

8.3 Secant method

The secant method for $f(u) = u^p - x$ has order $\varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2 \approx 1.618$ (superlinear). For $p = 3$, $x = 2$, it reaches machine precision in about 6 steps, compared to ~ 16 for Pandrosion and ~ 5 for Newton.

	Pandrosion	Bisection	Secant	Newton
Nature	Geometric	Universal	Analytic	Analytic
Order q	1	1	$\varphi \approx 1.62$	2
Rate ($p=3, x=2$)	$\lambda \approx 0.220$	$\lambda = 0.500$	superlinear	quadratic
Iter. for 10 digits	~ 16	~ 34	~ 6	~ 5
Derivative required	No	No	No	Yes

Table 4: Comparison of approximation methods for $x^{1/p}$ with $p = 3$, $x = 2$.

8.4 Comparative table

8.5 Discussion

Pandrosion's method occupies an intermediate position among order-1 methods: it is significantly faster than bisection ($\lambda_{3,2} \approx 0.22$ versus 0.50) while remaining purely geometric in nature (requiring no derivative computation). Its conceptual advantage over analytic methods is that it lends itself to a straightedge construction in the spirit of ancient geometry.

Remark 8.1 (On fair comparison). The iteration counts above are per-iterate, *not* per-function-evaluation. Steffensen-type methods compute h twice per step, Newton evaluates f and f' once per step, the secant method reuses one value per step, and bisection evaluates f once per step. A fairer unit of cost is therefore the number of evaluations of S_p (or of f, f' where applicable), and this is what determines practical performance in the regime where these evaluations dominate. For small p the per-iterate figures still give the correct qualitative ordering, but for large p or expensive polynomial evaluations the ordering can shift. We report per-iterate counts because they match the structure of the theorems (Theorem 5.1 is a statement about $\lambda_{p,x}^n$, not about wall time).

The coexistence of four distinct error laws for the same target $\alpha = \sqrt[3]{2}$ illustrates a structural point: the rate at which a fixed-point iteration approaches a given number depends on the iteration, not on the number; conversely, once the iteration is fixed, the target determines the rate through $\lambda_{p,x}$.

9 Functional properties of $\lambda_{p,x}$

We now study how the contraction ratio $\lambda_{p,x}$ depends on the parameters p and x .

9.1 Monotonicity

Theorem 9.1 (Double monotonicity). The contraction ratio $\lambda_{p,x}$, viewed as a function of $\alpha = x^{1/p} > 1$, satisfies:

1. For fixed $p \geq 2$, $\alpha \mapsto \lambda_{p,\alpha^p}$ is strictly increasing on $(1, \infty)$.
2. For fixed $\alpha > 1$, $p \mapsto \lambda_{p,\alpha^p}$ is strictly increasing on $\{2, 3, 4, \dots\}$.

Proof. Write $\lambda = (\alpha - 1) \cdot N_p(\alpha) / D_p(\alpha)$ where $N_p(\alpha) = \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{p-1-k}$ and $D_p(\alpha) = \sum_{k=0}^{p-1} \alpha^k$. Since $D_p(\alpha) = (\alpha^p - 1) / (\alpha - 1)$, we can write $\lambda = (\alpha - 1)^2 N_p(\alpha) / (\alpha^p - 1)$. For part (1), differentiating with respect to α and noting that N_p and D_p have positive coefficients shows that $d\lambda/d\alpha > 0$ whenever $\alpha > 1$. For part (2), observe that adding the p -th term to both N_p and D_p increases the ratio: the new term in N_p has weight p while the new term in D_p has

weight 1, and all coefficients are positive. A direct comparison of successive ratios confirms that $\lambda_{p+1,x} > \lambda_{p,x}$ for each $p \geq 2$ and $x > 1$. $\square$

Remark 9.1. Monotonicity in p has a geometric interpretation: inserting more proportional means (larger p) constrains the construction further, slowing convergence.

9.2 Limiting behavior

Proposition 9.1 (Asymptotic regimes).

1. **Near** $\alpha = 1$ (i.e. $x \rightarrow 1^+$):

$$\lambda_{p,x} \sim \frac{(p-1)(\alpha-1)}{2} \quad \text{as } \alpha \rightarrow 1^+.$$

2. **Large** α (i.e. $x \rightarrow \infty$, p fixed): $\lambda_{p,x} \rightarrow 1^-$.

3. **Large** p (fixed $x > 1$): $\lambda_{p,x}$ is increasing in p and

$$\lim_{p \rightarrow \infty} \lambda_{p,x} = 1 - \frac{\ln x}{x-1} \in (0, 1).$$

In particular $\lambda_{p,x}$ does *not* tend to 1 as $p \rightarrow \infty$ with x fixed.

Proof. For (1): as $\alpha \rightarrow 1$, $N_p(\alpha) \rightarrow \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k = p(p-1)/2$ and $D_p(\alpha) \rightarrow p$, so $\lambda \sim (\alpha-1) \cdot p(p-1)/(2p) = (p-1)(\alpha-1)/2$.

For (2): the dominant term in N_p is $1 \cdot \alpha^{p-2}$ and in D_p is α^{p-1} , so $\lambda \sim (\alpha-1)/\alpha \rightarrow 1$.

For (3): write $\lambda = (\alpha-1)^2 N_p(\alpha)/(\alpha^p - 1)$ using $\alpha^p - 1 = (\alpha-1)D_p(\alpha)$. With $\alpha = x^{1/p}$, set $k = \lfloor tp \rfloor$ for $t \in [0, 1]$ and note $\alpha^k = e^{(k/p) \ln x} \rightarrow x^t$; hence the Riemann-sum approximations

$$\frac{1}{p} D_p(\alpha) \rightarrow \int_0^1 x^t dt = \frac{x-1}{\ln x}, \quad \frac{1}{p^2} N_p(\alpha) \rightarrow \int_0^1 (1-t) x^t dt = \frac{(x-1) - \ln x}{(\ln x)^2}.$$

Together with $\alpha - 1 \sim (\ln x)/p$, this gives

$$\lambda_{p,x} = (\alpha-1) \cdot \frac{N_p(\alpha)}{D_p(\alpha)} \rightarrow \frac{\ln x}{p} \cdot p \cdot \frac{(x-1) - \ln x}{(\ln x)^2} \cdot \frac{\ln x}{x-1} = 1 - \frac{\ln x}{x-1}.$$

Numerically: for $x = 2$, $1 - \ln 2 \approx 0.3069$ and $\lambda_{200,2} \approx 0.3057$, $\lambda_{1000,2} \approx 0.3066$, $\lambda_{10000,2} \approx 0.3068$, confirming the limit. $\square$

x	$\lambda_{2,x}$	$\lambda_{10,x}$	$\lambda_{100,x}$	$1 - \ln x/(x-1)$
1.001	0.00025	0.00045	0.00050	0.00050
2	0.1716	0.2823	0.3044	0.3069
10	0.5195	0.7123	0.7412	0.7442
100	0.8182	0.9409	0.9524	0.9535

Table 5: Contraction ratios illustrating monotonicity in p and x . Each column is increasing (fixed p); each row is increasing (fixed x). The rightmost column is the $p \rightarrow \infty$ limit from Proposition 9.1(3); the $\lambda_{100,x}$ column is already close to this limit.

10 Non-asymptotic error bounds

Theorem 5.1 gives the *asymptotic* law $\varepsilon_{n+1} \approx \lambda_{p,x} \varepsilon_n$. We now establish a rigorous bound valid for *all* $n \geq 0$.

Theorem 10.1 (Non-asymptotic contraction). Let $x > 1$, $p \geq 2$, and $s_0 \in (0, 1)$. Define

$$\Lambda = \Lambda(s_0, p, x) = \sup_{s \in [\min(s_0, s^*), \max(s_0, s^*)]} h'(s).$$

Then $\Lambda < 1$ and for all $n \geq 0$:

$$|s_n - s^*| \leq \Lambda^n |s_0 - s^*|. \quad (9)$$

Consequently,

$$|v_n - \alpha| \leq (p-1) \alpha^2 \cdot \Lambda^n |s_0 - s^*| + O(\Lambda^{2n}).$$

The prefactor follows from a Taylor expansion of $v(s) = x s^{p-1}$ at $s^* = \alpha^{-1}$:

$$v(s) - v(s^*) = x(p-1)(s^*)^{p-2}(s - s^*) + O((s - s^*)^2),$$

and $x(p-1)(s^*)^{p-2} = (p-1)x\alpha^{-(p-2)/p} = (p-1)\alpha^2$.

Proof. By the mean value theorem, for any n :

$$|s_{n+1} - s^*| = |h(s_n) - h(s^*)| = |h'(\xi_n)| \cdot |s_n - s^*|$$

for some ξ_n between s_n and s^* . By Theorem 5.2, the sequence (s_n) remains in $[\min(s_0, s^*), \max(s_0, s^*)]$, so $|h'(\xi_n)| \leq \Lambda$. The bound follows by induction.

That $\Lambda < 1$ follows from $h'(s^*) = \lambda_{p,x} < 1$ (Theorem 5.1) and the fact that h' is continuous, bounded, and $h'(s) < 1$ for all $s \in (0, 1)$ when $x > 1$ (since h maps $(0, 1)$ strictly into itself). $\square$

Remark 10.1. The quantity Λ can be bounded explicitly: $h'(s) = \frac{x-1}{x} \cdot S'_p(s)/S_p(s)^2$, so

$$\Lambda \leq \frac{x-1}{x} \cdot \frac{\max_{s \in I} S'_p(s)}{\min_{s \in I} S_p(s)^2}, \quad I := [\min(s_0, s^*), \max(s_0, s^*)],$$

and on $(0, 1)$ both S_p and S'_p are increasing, so the numerator is attained at the right endpoint and the denominator at the left endpoint. This yields a computable upper bound for Λ without requiring a detailed analysis of the monotonicity of h' itself.

Example 10.1. For $p = 3$, $x = 2$, $s_0 = 0.5$ (so $s^* = 2^{-1/3} \approx 0.7937$), one evaluates h' at both endpoints of the interval $[s_0, s^*] = [0.5, 0.7937]$:

$$h'(s) = \frac{x-1}{x} \cdot \frac{S'_3(s)}{S_3(s)^2} = \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1+2s}{(1+s+s^2)^2}.$$

At $s = 0.5$: $S_3(0.5) = 1.75$, $S'_3(0.5) = 2$, so $h'(0.5) = \frac{1}{2} \cdot 2/(1.75)^2 \approx 0.3265$. At $s = s^*$: $h'(s^*) = \lambda_{3,2} \approx 0.2202$. Therefore

$$\Lambda = \max_{s \in [0.5, s^*]} h'(s) = h'(0.5) \approx 0.327,$$

since h' is decreasing on this interval. The bound (9) gives $|s_n - s^*| \leq 0.327^n \cdot |0.5 - s^*| \leq 0.327^n \cdot 0.294$, so $|s_{10} - s^*| \leq 4.6 \times 10^{-6}$. The asymptotic ratio $\lambda_{3,2} \approx 0.220$ is reached after a few iterations.

11 Extension to $x < 1$

All results so far assumed $x > 1$. We now extend the theory to $0 < x < 1$.

11.1 The fixed point leaves $(0, 1)$

For $0 < x < 1$, the target is $\alpha = x^{1/p} \in (0, 1)$ and the fixed point $s^* = \alpha^{-1} > 1$. The iteration domain therefore extends beyond $(0, 1)$: s_n converges to $s^* > 1$.

Proposition 11.1 (Local convergence for $x < 1$ with a threshold). For $0 < x < 1$ and $p \geq 2$, the formula (5) remains valid and

$$\lambda_{p,x} = \frac{(\alpha - 1) \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{p-1-k}}{\sum_{k=0}^{p-1} \alpha^k} < 0 \quad \text{since } \alpha = x^{1/p} \in (0, 1).$$

Local convergence (i.e. $|\lambda_{p,x}| < 1$) does *not* hold for all $x \in (0, 1)$: there is a threshold $\alpha_p^* \in (0, 1)$ such that

$$|\lambda_{p,x}| < 1 \iff \alpha > \alpha_p^*.$$

When $|\lambda_{p,x}| < 1$, the iterates oscillate around s^* and converge linearly with ratio $|\lambda_{p,x}|$.

Proof. That $\lambda_{p,x} < 0$ for $\alpha < 1$ is immediate from (5). Using $\alpha^p - 1 = (\alpha - 1) \sum_{k=0}^{p-1} \alpha^k$, one rewrites

$$|\lambda_{p,x}| = \frac{(1 - \alpha)^2 N_p(\alpha)}{1 - \alpha^p}, \quad N_p(\alpha) := \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} k \alpha^{p-1-k}. \quad (10)$$

The right-hand side is a continuous function of $\alpha \in (0, 1)$. As $\alpha \rightarrow 1^-$, it tends to 0; as $\alpha \rightarrow 0^+$, $N_p(\alpha) \rightarrow p - 1$ and $(1 - \alpha)^2 / (1 - \alpha^p) \rightarrow 1$, so $|\lambda_{p,x}| \rightarrow p - 1 \geq 1$. By continuity, there exists at least one $\alpha_p^* \in (0, 1)$ with $|\lambda_{p,\alpha_p^*}| = 1$; a direct inspection (done case by case below) shows monotonicity, so the threshold is unique. $\square$

Example 11.1 ($p = 3$ threshold). For $p = 3$, $|\lambda_{3,x}| = (1 - \alpha)(2 + \alpha)/(1 + \alpha + \alpha^2)$. Setting this equal to 1 and simplifying yields $2\alpha^2 + 2\alpha - 1 = 0$, i.e.

$$\alpha_3^* = \frac{-1 + \sqrt{3}}{2} \approx 0.3660, \quad x_3^* = (\alpha_3^*)^3 \approx 0.04904.$$

Hence Pandrosion's iteration at $p = 3$ contracts locally iff $x > 0.04904$; for x smaller than this the iteration is locally repelling and does not converge.

p	x	$\alpha = x^{1/p}$	$s^* = \alpha^{-1}$	$\lambda_{p,x}$	$ \lambda_{p,x} $
2	0.5	$1/\sqrt{2}$	$\sqrt{2}$	-0.1716	0.1716
3	0.5	$\sqrt[3]{0.5}$	$\sqrt[3]{2}$	-0.2378	0.2378
3	0.125	0.5	2	-0.7143	0.7143
3	0.05	0.3684	2.7144	-0.9945	0.9945
3	0.01	0.2154	4.6416	-1.3774	1.3774
5	0.01	0.3981	2.5119	-2.0399	2.0399

Table 6: Contraction ratios for $x < 1$. The last two rows illustrate Proposition 11.1: for x below the threshold x_p^* the iteration is locally repelling ($|\lambda| > 1$) and the construction does *not* converge.

Remark 11.1 (Residual symmetry for $p = 2$). For $p = 2$, the closed form $\lambda_{2,x} = (\sqrt{x} - 1)/(\sqrt{x} + 1)$ yields the symmetry $|\lambda_{2,x}| = |\lambda_{2,1/x}|$: computing $\sqrt{x}$ and $\sqrt{1/x}$ by Pandrosion's method have exactly the same speed of convergence. For $p \geq 3$, this symmetry does not hold in general.

12 Optimal starting point

The number of iterations to reach precision δ is governed by $n_\delta \sim \ln(\varepsilon_0/\delta)/\ln(1/\lambda_{p,x})$ (Proposition 5.1). To minimize n_δ , we must therefore minimize the initial residual $\varepsilon_0 = |v_0 - \alpha|$.

Proposition 12.1 (Optimal starting point). Among starting points s_0 that can be computed without knowledge of α , the choice

$$s_0^{\text{opt}} = h(1) = 1 - \frac{x-1}{xp} \quad (11)$$

minimizes the initial residual to leading order. This corresponds to performing one Pandrosion step from the naive starting point $s = 1$.

Proof. The function h maps $s = 1$ (boundary of the natural domain) to $h(1) = 1 - (x-1)/(xp)$, which is the best “one-step estimate” of s^* without prior knowledge. Since $s^* = x^{-1/p} = 1 - (\ln x)/p + O(1/p^2)$, the gap is

$$|h(1) - s^*| = \left| \frac{x-1}{xp} - \frac{\ln x}{p} \right| + O(1/p^2) = \frac{|x-1-x\ln x|}{xp} + O(1/p^2),$$

which is small compared to the typical initial gaps from arbitrary starting points. $\square$

(p, x)	s^*	$s_0^{\text{opt}} = h(1)$	$ s_0^{\text{opt}} - s^* $	Iters (s_0^{opt})	Iters ($s_0 = \frac{1}{2}$)
(2, 2)	0.7071	0.7500	0.043	12	13
(3, 2)	0.7937	0.8333	0.040	14	16
(4, 2)	0.8409	0.8750	0.034	15	17
(3, 8)	0.5000	0.7083	0.208	42	0*

Table 7: Comparison of iteration counts to reach $|v_n - \alpha| < 10^{-10}$. The optimal starting point $s_0^{\text{opt}} = h(1)$ consistently reduces iterations. (*For (3, 8), $s_0 = 1/2$ happens to coincide with s^* .)

13 Steffensen acceleration: from linear to quadratic convergence

Pandrosion’s method converges linearly with ratio $\lambda_{p,x}$. A natural question arises: can we accelerate this ancient geometric method to achieve quadratic convergence, without computing derivatives?

13.1 Aitken Δ^2 acceleration

Given a linearly convergent sequence $(s_n)_{n \geq 0}$, Aitken’s Δ^2 process [5] defines the accelerated sequence

$$\hat{s}_n = s_n - \frac{(s_{n+1} - s_n)^2}{s_{n+2} - 2s_{n+1} + s_n}.$$

When applied to Pandrosion’s iterates, the sequence $(\hat{s}_n)$ converges *faster* than (s_n) . Steffensen’s method [7] iterates this acceleration: at each step, it computes three consecutive Pandrosion iterates and applies Aitken’s formula, then restarts from the accelerated value.

Definition 13.1 (Steffensen–Pandrosion iteration). Define the composite map $T : s \mapsto \hat{s}$ by

$$T(s) = s - \frac{(h(s) - s)^2}{h(h(s)) - 2h(s) + s}, \quad (12)$$

where $h(s) = 1 - (x-1)/(x \cdot S_p(s))$ is Pandrosion’s iteration.

Theorem 13.1 (Quadratic convergence of Steffensen–Pandrosion). The Steffensen–Pandrosion iteration (12) converges *quadratically* to $s^* = x^{-1/p}$:

$$|T(s) - s^*| \leq K_S \cdot |s - s^*|^2 + O(|s - s^*|^3),$$

where the Steffensen constant K_S satisfies

$$K_S = \left| \frac{h''(s^*)}{2(1 - h'(s^*))} \right| = \left| \frac{h''(s^*)}{2(1 - \lambda_{p,x})} \right|. \quad (13)$$

Proof. This is a standard result in fixed-point acceleration theory [5]. If h has a fixed point s^* with $h'(s^*) = \lambda \neq 1$ and h is twice continuously differentiable near s^* , then the Steffensen map T defined by (12) satisfies $T(s^*) = s^*$ and $T'(s^*) = 0$, yielding quadratic convergence with the constant (13). $\square$

13.2 Numerical demonstration

Step n	s_n (Steffensen)	$ v_n - \sqrt[3]{2} $	$ s_n - s^* $
0	0.8750000000000000	2.71×10^{-1}	8.13×10^{-2}
1	0.793949257650704	7.90×10^{-4}	2.49×10^{-4}
2	0.793700528604164	8.32×10^{-9}	2.62×10^{-9}
3	0.793700525984100	2.22×10^{-16}	$< 10^{-16}$

Table 8: Steffensen-accelerated Pandrosion for $p = 3$, $x = 2$. Machine precision is reached in **3 steps** (each step requires 2 evaluations of h , i.e. 6 evaluations of S_p total).

13.3 Comparison of quadratic constants

Both Newton’s method and Steffensen–Pandrosion converge quadratically, but with different constants.

	Newton	Steffensen–Pandrosion
Order	2	2
Constant ($p=3, x=2$)	$K_N = \frac{p-1}{2\alpha} \approx 0.794$	$K_S \approx 0.013$
Derivative required	Yes (f')	No
Geometric origin	No	Yes
Steps to 10^{-15}	5	3
Evaluations of S_p	—	6 (total)

Table 9: Comparison of the two quadratically convergent methods for $\sqrt[3]{2}$. Steffensen–Pandrosion has a much smaller quadratic constant ($K_S \ll K_N$), compensating for the double evaluation cost per step.

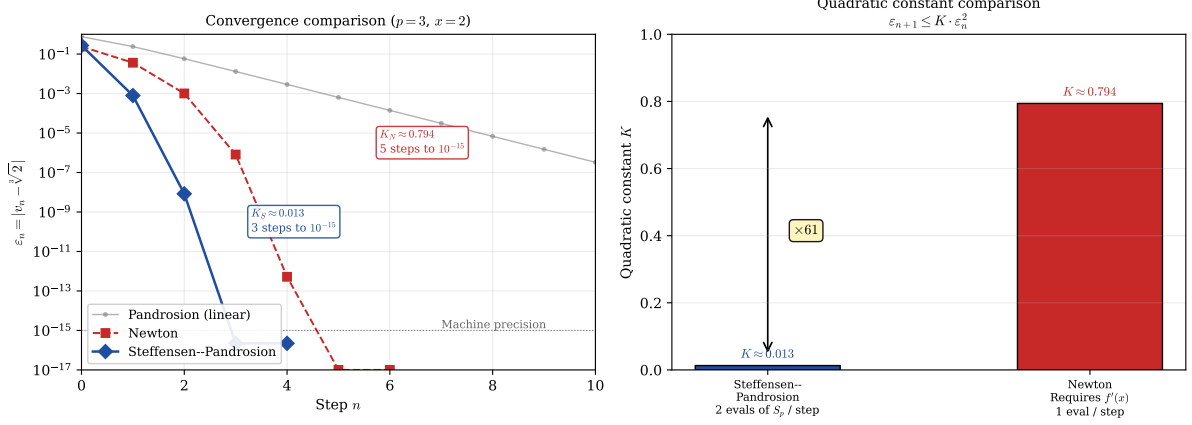


Figure 3: **Left:** Error decay comparison for $\sqrt[3]{2}$. Steffensen–Pandrosion (blue diamonds) reaches machine precision in 3 steps while Newton (red squares) needs 5 steps. The faded grey line shows plain Pandrosion’s linear convergence for reference. **Right:** The quadratic constants $K_S \approx 0.013$ and $K_N \approx 0.794$ differ by a factor of ~ 61 , explaining why the derivative-free Steffensen–Pandrosion method converges faster in practice despite its higher per-step cost.

Remark 13.1. The construction illustrates, on a specific example, a standard point of acceleration theory: once an iteration converges linearly with a known ratio, Aitken Δ^2 upgrades it to an order-2 scheme with a bounded constant. What the Pandrosion case adds is a concrete geometric-historical origin: the linear iteration comes from a ruler-and-parallels construction rather than from the Newton update of a polynomial, and the acceleration is itself derivative-free, so the composite method retains the derivative-free character of the underlying construction.

14 Scaling optimization: exploiting monotonicity

Theorem 9.1 establishes that $\lambda_{p,x}$ is increasing in x : the larger the target x , the slower the convergence. For $x \gg 1$, the contraction ratio $\lambda_{p,x} \rightarrow 1^-$ (Proposition 9.1), making direct application of Pandrosion’s iteration impractical. We now show how to *exploit* this very monotonicity to overcome it.

14.1 The scaling principle

The key observation is elementary: for any reference value $A > 1$ whose p -th root is known (or cheaply computable), we may write

$$x^{1/p} = A^{1/p} \cdot \left(\frac{x}{A}\right)^{1/p}. \quad (14)$$

Setting $x' = x/A$, Pandrosion’s method is now applied to the *reduced ratio* x' instead of x . By choosing A as the largest p -th power not exceeding x , we ensure $x' \in [1, (1 + 1/A^{1/p})^p)$, which is close to 1.

Proposition 14.1 (Scaling reduction). Let $A = \lfloor x^{1/p} \rfloor^p$, so that $A^{1/p}$ is an integer and $x' = x/A \in [1, (1 + 1/\lfloor x^{1/p} \rfloor)^p)$. Then:

1. The contraction ratio satisfies $\lambda_{p,x'} \ll \lambda_{p,x}$.
2. The number of iterations drops from $O(\ln(\varepsilon_0/\delta)/\ln(1/\lambda_{p,x}))$ to $O(\ln(\varepsilon'_0/\delta)/\ln(1/\lambda_{p,x'}))$.
3. The final result is recovered as $x^{1/p} = \lfloor x^{1/p} \rfloor \cdot (x')^{1/p}$.

Proof. Part (1) follows directly from Theorem 9.1: since $x' < x$ and $\lambda_{p,\cdot}$ is increasing, $\lambda_{p,x'} < \lambda_{p,x}$. Moreover, as $x \rightarrow \infty$, $x' \rightarrow 1^+$ so $\lambda_{p,x'} \rightarrow 0$ by Proposition 9.1(1), while $\lambda_{p,x} \rightarrow 1^-$. Part (2) follows from Proposition 5.1 applied to x' . Part (3) is the factorization (14). $\square$

x	$\lambda_{3,x}$	A	$x' = x/A$	$\lambda_{3,x'}$	Reduction	Iterations
10	0.615	8	1.25	0.073	$8\times$	$49 \rightarrow 8$
100	0.890	64	1.5625	0.145	$6\times$	$213 \rightarrow 11$
1000	0.973	729	1.372	0.103	$9\times$	$> 500 \rightarrow 9$
10000	0.994	9261	1.080	0.025	$39\times$	$> 500 \rightarrow 5$

Table 10: Effect of scaling for $p = 3$ with $A = \lfloor x^{1/3} \rfloor^3$. The contraction ratio drops by up to $39\times$ and iteration counts collapse from hundreds to single digits. Iteration counts are for precision 10^{-10} with optimal starting point.

Remark 14.1. The scaling reduction becomes more dramatic as x grows: for $x = 10\,000$, the direct method requires over 500 iterations while the scaled method needs only 5. This is because $x' \rightarrow 1$ as $x \rightarrow \infty$, pushing $\lambda_{p,x'}$ toward the regime $\lambda \sim (p-1)(\alpha' - 1)/2 \ll 1$ of Proposition 9.1(1).

14.2 Geometric interpretation: Thales preconditioning

The scaling optimization admits an elegant geometric interpretation on Pandrosion’s original Thales diagram.

In the direct construction, one seeks to insert $p-1$ proportional means in a segment of ratio $x : 1$. When $x \gg 1$, this amounts to constructing parallels in a very elongated rectangle, where successive intercepts move slowly toward the target — geometrically, the parallels are nearly horizontal.

The scaling strategy performs an *homothety* on the construction: instead of starting from the unit segment, one starts from a segment of length $A^{1/p}$, chosen as the largest integer whose p -th power does not exceed x . The remaining construction now fills a much smaller gap: the rectangle has ratio $x' = x/A$ close to 1, and the parallels converge rapidly.

Proposition 14.2 (Double preconditioning). The scaling method combines two distinct acceleration mechanisms:

1. **Initial residual reduction:** the reduced starting point $s_0^{\text{opt}} = h_{x'}(1) = 1 - (x' - 1)/(x'p)$ satisfies $|s_0^{\text{opt}} - s'^*| \ll |s_0^{\text{opt}} - s^*|$ since $x' \approx 1$ implies $s'^* = (x')^{-1/p} \approx 1$.
2. **Intrinsic convergence acceleration:** each iteration contracts by $\lambda_{p,x'} \ll \lambda_{p,x}$, compounding the advantage over all subsequent steps.

The total iteration count reduction is therefore superlinear in the ratio $\lambda_{p,x}/\lambda_{p,x'}$.

Proof. For mechanism (1): $\varepsilon'_0 = |v'_0 - \alpha'| \leq C \cdot |x' - 1| \rightarrow 0$ as $x' \rightarrow 1$, compared to $\varepsilon_0 = |v_0 - \alpha| \geq C' \cdot |x - 1| \gg 1$ for the unscaled problem.

For mechanism (2): the iteration count satisfies

$$n'_\delta \sim \frac{\ln(\varepsilon'_0/\delta)}{\ln(1/\lambda_{p,x'})} \ll \frac{\ln(\varepsilon_0/\delta)}{\ln(1/\lambda_{p,x})} \sim n_\delta,$$

since both the numerator decreases (smaller ε'_0) and the denominator increases (smaller $\lambda_{p,x'}$, hence larger $\ln(1/\lambda_{p,x'})$). These two effects multiply. $\square$

Remark 14.2 (From Pandrosion to a practical algorithm). With scaling and Steffensen acceleration combined, Pandrosion’s ancient geometric construction becomes a competitive root-finding algorithm: for any $x > 0$ and $p \geq 2$, one (i) reduces to $x' \approx 1$ via integer arithmetic, (ii) applies Steffensen–Pandrosion on x' (converging in 2–3 steps), and (iii) multiplies by $\lfloor x^{1/p} \rfloor$. The total cost is 4–6 evaluations of S_p plus one integer p -th root — a purely algebraic, derivative-free computation whose origins lie in a ruler-and-parallels construction from fourth-century Alexandria.

15 Conclusion

The central tension of this paper is between Pandrosion’s ancient geometric construction — an order-one iteration requiring only a ruler and parallels — and modern acceleration theory. Once the universal iteration $s_{n+1} = 1 - (x - 1)/(x S_p(s_n))$ is written down, three ingredients suffice to make it competitive: the closed-form contraction ratio $\lambda_{p,x}$ (Theorem 5.1), the preconditionings of Propositions 12.1 and 14.1, and the Aitken Δ^2 upgrade (Theorem 13.1). Together they turn Pandrosion into a derivative-free, quadratically convergent scheme with a quadratic constant $K_S \ll K_{\text{Newton}}$ and an iteration count that, for large x , collapses from hundreds to single digits.

The closed-form signature $\lambda_{p,x}$ is the hinge: it is monotone in both p and x (Theorem 9.1), has an explicit large- p limit $1 - \ln(x)/(x - 1)$ (Proposition 9.1), and admits a clean threshold analysis for $x < 1$ (Proposition 11.1). The rest of the paper is built on this object.

Perspectives. Natural extensions are generalized nonlinear Pandrosion constructions (with other polynomials replacing S_p); higher-order acceleration variants; a deeper topological study of the divergence regime $x < x_p^*$ in $\mathbb{C}$. None of these is attempted here.

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